

Orientalism on the Margins

The Ottoman Empire under Russian Eyes

VICTOR TAKI

Throughout its modern history, Russia was more frequently at war with the Ottoman Empire than with any other power. Russo-Ottoman wars took place between the late 17th and the late 19th centuries and were paralleled by other forms of contact, including captivity, religious pilgrimages, diplomacy, and later tourism and scientific exploration.¹ The intensity of this interaction is reflected in the voluminous literature about the Ottoman Empire that was published in Russian before 1917.² Russian and translated Western accounts of captivity, religious and secular travelogues, memoirs, and statistical descriptions are noteworthy not only because they were numerous, but because before the (remarkably late) appearance of *osmanistika* as a separate branch of Orientalist science devoted to Ottoman Turkey, these nonscholarly writings contained the quasi-totality of Russian knowledge about the rival empire.³ Aimed at a wide audience,

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¹ One could, of course, extend the chronology of Russo-Ottoman wars in both directions by mentioning Selim II's campaign against Astrakhan in 1569, the capture of Azov by the Don Cossacks in 1637, or the military actions in Transcaucasia in 1914–17. Nevertheless, the ten Russo-Turkish wars that took place between 1676 and 1878 stand out. They occurred every 15–30 years, were waged primarily in European Turkey, and were justified more or less explicitly by the idea of liberating the Balkan Christians.

² *Bibliografiia Turtsii (1713–1917)* (Moscow: Izdatel'stvo Vostochnoi literatury, 1961) lists over 4,000 items, the majority of which are of a nonscholarly nature.

³ From the mid-1820s on, Ottoman Turkish was continuously taught to prospective staff of Russian diplomatic missions at the Education Section of Oriental Languages of the Asiatic Department of the Ministry of Foreign Affairs; see B. M. Dantsig, *Izuchenie Blizhnego Vostoka v Rossii (XIX–nachalo XX vv.)* (Moscow: Nauka, 1968), 83–85. In the first half of the 19th century, the language was also taught continuously at Kazan University by A. K. Kazembek and I. N. Berezin, and somewhat intermittently at St. Petersburg University by O. I. Senkovskii, Dzhafar

these materials can plausibly be taken as evidence of more or less widespread assumptions that educated Russians held about Ottoman Turkey at least until the 1840s, when there appeared the first general descriptions written by professional Orientalists for nonspecialists.⁴ By virtue of their sheer number, these publications constituted the basic horizon for those who engaged in highbrow intellectual discussions as well as for those who limited themselves to the passive reading of thick journals and newspapers. Through them, the Ottoman Empire emerged as an element of the mental background against which Russian intellectuals later discussed their country's relation to Asia and Europe.⁵

An analysis of these sources is timely for at least two reasons. First, contacts with Ottoman Turkey constitute an aspect of Russia's "discovery of the Orient" that remains unappreciated in the modern historiography of Russian Orientalism. In the wake of the important work that has been done on "Russia's own Orient" in the last 15 years, it might be worthwhile to turn to the "Orient" beyond the empire's borders in order to describe its function in the Russian imperial imagination.⁶ Second, discussions of Russian views of "Europe" and "Asia" are sometimes

Topchibashev, and V. F. Dittel' (ibid., 33, 40–41, 53–54, 63). However, *osmanistika* as a separate branch of Russian academic Orientalism emerged only in the second half of the 19th century, i.e., later than Arabistics, Turkology, Sanskritology, or Sinology. A. O. Mukhlinskii, who held the chair for Ottoman Turkish at St. Petersburg University between 1849 and 1866, published the first textbook in 1856–59 (ibid., 65–67). V. D. Smirnov, who was appointed to the chair for Ottoman Turkish in 1873, can be called the first Russian *osmanist* in the sense that he not only was specially trained but also left a significant scholarly legacy, including, among other things, a renowned "Compilation of the Works of Ottoman Literature" and "History of Turkish Literature." Besides language and literature, he also systematically taught the history of the Ottoman Empire (ibid., 138–39). For a recent discussion of academic Orientalism in Russia, see Vera Tolz, "European, National, and (Anti-) Imperial: The Formation of Academic Oriental Studies in Late Tsarist and Early Soviet Russia," in *Orientalism and Empire in Russia*, ed. Michael David Fox, Peter Holquist, and Alexander Martin (Bloomington, IN: Slavica Publishers, 2006), 107–34, as well as her *Russia's Own Orient: The Politics of Identity and Oriental Studies in the Late Imperial and Early Soviet Period* (Oxford: Oxford University Press, forthcoming May 2011).

⁴ V. V. Grigor'ev, "Poezdka v Konstantinopol' Izafeti Makluba," *Odesskii al'manakh na 1840 g.* (Odessa, 1839), 642–701; I. N. Berezin, "Obzor trekhletnego puteshestviia po Vostoku," *Zhurnal Ministerstva narodnogo prosveshcheniia* 55, no. 7 (1847): 1–24.

⁵ Accordingly, "Orientalism" in this article is taken in its broader meaning of a "style of thought based upon an ontological and epistemological distinction made between 'the Orient' and (most of the time) 'the Occident'"; see Edward Said, *Orientalism* (London: Penguin, 2003), 7.

⁶ On Russian Orientalism and the eastern borderlands, see Daniel R. Brower and Edward J. Lazzerini, *Russia's Orient: Imperial Borderlands and Peoples* (Bloomington: Indiana University Press, 1997). The Caucasian aspect of Russian Orientalism has been explored by Austin Jersild, *Orientalism and Empire: North Caucasus Mountain Peoples and the Georgian Frontier, 1845–1917* (Montreal: McGill University Press, 2002); and Susan Layton, *Russian Literature and Empire: Conquest of the Caucasus from Pushkin to Tolstoy* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1994). For general study of Russian Orientalism in both the narrow academic and the broader "imaginative" meaning of the term, see David Schimmelpenninck van der Oye, *Russian*

too quick to subsume actual political entities under these rather problematic categories. Before the "Orient" became a space of European colonial dominance (in which Russia had its own share), it bore the concrete name of Ottoman (Persian, Manchu) Empire and constituted a formidable, if diminishing, military challenge. The problem to be addressed is precisely how Orientalist discourse came to structure the perception of one continental empire by the elite of another.⁷

This article examines the Orientalization of the Ottoman Empire in Russian literature before the middle of the 19th century and its role in the articulation of modern Russian identity. The symbolic construction of a rival empire as the "Orient" served to sustain the representation of Russia as part of "Europe" against claims to the contrary. This perception of the "Other" did not emerge overnight. Instead, it crystallized gradually in the context of the Russian elite's conscious and systematic search for models that resulted in Russia's Westernization. Launched by Peter the Great, this process led to the discovery of differences between the empire of the sultans and other powers. These differences, in turn, served as the basis for the Orientalization of Ottoman Turkey that occurred under the combined impact of the Russo-Ottoman wars and of the Russian elite's growing familiarity with Western accounts of the Ottoman Empire. The wars demonstrated the superiority of the European military models adopted by Peter and his successors, while translations of French and British Orientalist texts provided the language to articulate this new sense of superiority.

At some point, Russian accounts of the Ottoman Empire started to follow closely the Western model of Orientalist description. While reproducing these tropes, Russian authors made their own contribution to the growing currency of Orientalist discourse—one that was distinct not so much because of Russia's special historical relationship to Asia as due to its persistent marginality within the symbolic geography of Europe.⁸ Continued references by Westerners to Russia's "semi-barbarous character" were merely one manifestation of this marginality.⁹

Orientalism: Asia in the Russian Mind from Peter the Great to the Emigration (New Haven: Yale University Press, 2010).

⁷ For the discussion of Orientalist representations of Persia, see Ekaterina Andreeva, *Russia and Iran in the "Great Game": Travelogues and Orientalism* (London: Routledge, 2008).

⁸ In the words of Adeb Khalid, Russian Orientalism was at least as much about Russia's "unrequited relationship" with "Europe" as about its relations with "Asia"; see his "Russian History and the Debate over Orientalism," in *Orientalism and Empire in Russia*, 29. Khalid's piece originally appeared in the debate on Russian Orientalism in *Kritika* 1, 4 (2000): 691–727; Khalid was responding to Nathaniel Knight, "Grigor'ev in Orenburg, 1851–1862: Russian Orientalism in the Service of Empire?" *Slavic Review* 59, 1 (2000): 74–100.

⁹ Marshall Poe, *A People Born To Slavery: Russia in Early Modern Ethnography, 1478–1750* (Ithaca, NY: Cornell University Press, 2000); Larry Wolff, *Inventing Eastern Europe: The Map of Civilization on the Mind of Enlightenment* (Stanford, CA: Stanford University Press, 1994).

Another, no less important, aspect was a certain distance from the Western nations that Russians maintained in their role as both "apprentices" and "critics" of European civilization. Through their manipulation of Western Orientalist idioms, Russian observers of the Ottoman Empire both asserted their membership in this civilization and questioned its meaning. As a result, their diatribes against the traditional Ottoman system came to be paralleled by implicit or explicit disapproval of the Westernization policies that the sultans eventually began to pursue. In this sense, Russian Orientalism was simultaneously a manifestation of Russian Occidentalism.

The fact that Russia was the first country to undergo Westernization constituted a major peculiarity of its relations if not with Asia as a whole, then at least with the Ottoman Empire. This became especially important for the Ottomans after successive defeats in wars with their northern neighbor induced the sultans to emulate Petrine policies of military modernization. As a result, the position of Ottoman Turkey with respect to Russia became not unlike Russia's position with respect to other European nations. Although the Ottomans started to adopt *European* models, they were following the *Russian* example in doing so. On the one hand, this process threatened to eliminate Russia's military superiority and undermine the Orientalizing representations that had cast Ottoman Turkey as stagnant and decaying. On the other hand, the Ottoman Empire was embarking on the same path about a century later than Russia, and the resulting historical gap that separated Petrine and Ottoman Westernization allowed Russian observers to present the Ottoman policies as always lacking in one or another crucial respect. Their strategy was to turn the benefit of historical hindsight into a "positional superiority" that "puts the Westerner in a whole series of possible relationships with the Orient without ever losing him the relative upper hand."¹⁰

Looking for Models

Since the beginning of the Russo-Ottoman wars in the late 17th century, the Ottoman army commanded the attention of Russian authors. Eventually, military organization emerged as the primary domain in which Ottoman otherness and Russian superiority were asserted. This, however, did not happen before a string of Russian victories during the 18th century. Although West European authors of the 17th century detected an Ottoman decline and attributed it to the despotic political system, there is little indication of any perceived military or political inferiority of the Ottoman Empire in Russian works of the period. The first clashes between the Russian and Ottoman armies in 1677–81 and 1686–1700 revealed the inadequacies of Russia's troops and strategy and

¹⁰ Said, *Orientalism*, 7.

made Russian military men speak respectfully about their rivals. Thus a participant of the Crimean and Azov campaigns of the 1680s and 1690s, Andrei Ivanovich Lyzlov, in his *Scythian History* of 1692, paid tribute to the Turks for their large numbers and "being always ready for war," their "singular promptness on assault," the sultans' personal leadership of their armies, and their attention to "armor and military weapons."¹¹ A late 17th-century *Description of the Ottoman Empire Composed by a Russian Captive* likewise described the Janissaries as "strong in war" (*na voinu krepki*), although it also noted that their "ways of war are not in accordance with science" (*a voina ikh ne po nauke est*).¹²

This attitude began to change immediately once the disastrous beginning of the Great Northern War demonstrated the superiority of the Swedish military model. Even before Russia could boast of a European-style army, the first Russian ambassador to Istanbul, P. A. Tolstoi, already voiced a low opinion of Ottoman war capacities, arguing that their military prowess was due only to their great numbers. His reports to Peter the Great characterized the Turks as ferocious in battle but often losing spirit once their first onslaught was repelled, after which they were usually unable to maintain order and retreated in complete chaos.¹³ Mentioning the Ottoman view that the Russians "lacked skill in the military art," Tolstoi nevertheless reported their "great fear of the newly built Russian navy"¹⁴ and asserted that they considered the Russian tsar to be very powerful¹⁵—an affirmation that seems doubtful in light of the fact that the Ottomans initially refused to accept a permanent Russian representative in Istanbul. While the battle of Poltava soon proved the worth of Peter's military reforms, the disastrous Pruth campaign that followed demonstrated that having a European-style army did not guarantee success in a war against the Turks and Tatars. Some 25 years later, this was only confirmed by the war of 1735–39, which despite a number of victories brought Russia few gains and huge human losses. Nevertheless, the Russian commander Burkhard Christoph von Münnich claimed that the war made the "Turks and Tatars respect the Russian army and treat Russian captives better" and reported the Turks as saying that they "were

¹¹ A. I. Lyzlov, *Skifskaiia istoriia* (Moscow: Nauka, 1990), 267, 270–71.

¹² "Opisanie Turetskoi imperii, sostavlennoe russkim, byvshim v plenu u turok vo vtoroi polovine XVII v.," *Pravoslavnyi palestinskii sbornik* 30 (1890): 24.

¹³ This became an accepted view for more than a century, as is clear from Andrei Pushkin's "Vzgliad na voennoe sostoianie Turetskoi imperii," *Syn otechestva* 107, no. 10 (1826): 189.

¹⁴ The bewilderment of the Ottomans at the sight of the new Russian navy, which was built by Peter at Voronezh and appeared on the Azov Sea in 1700, is registered by K. I. Kreis, "Ekstrakt iz zhurnala derzhannogo ot gospodina vitse-admirala Kreisa na puti iz Moskvy v Voronezh, s Voronezha v Azov, na Taganrog i k Kerchi, a ottuda paki nazad k Azovu, 1699," *Zapiski Gidrograficheskogo departamenta Morskogo ministerstva* 8 (1850): 367–94.

¹⁵ P. A. Tolstoi, *Russkii posol v Stambule* (Moscow: Nauka, 1985), 50.

no longer capable of withstanding the Russian fire either in the field or in their fortresses."¹⁶

The military sphere constituted an important dimension of the Orientalization of the Ottoman Empire, not so much on account of the Turks' inferiority as due to the apparent difference of a Turkish "way of war" that was thought to be the "consequence of [their] mores, [their] way of life, and [their very] character."¹⁷ Even after a string of victories in the second half of the 18th century, Russian participants in the Turkish wars were not always dismissive of their adversaries. As late as the second decade of the 19th century, the Russian military engineer Aleksei Ivanovich Martos ridiculed those amateurs of the military art who, unlike him, had never participated in any Turkish campaigns and thought that fighting Turks was easy because of their ignorance of military tactics and lack of good commanders. Pointing to the bitter lessons that the Turks had taught various European powers, Martos spoke highly of their "ardent courage and spirit of unparalleled valor" and admitted that "from the very first time, one could not help feeling horror and shuddering looking at the ferocious enemy rushing upon you with their banners and ensigns, which no Muslim ever abandons."¹⁸ The originality of the Turkish military establishment provoked sustained interest and warranted the creation of specialized expertise. On the eve of the war of 1828–29, one such self-styled "expert," Andrei Nikiforovich Pushkin, suggested a number of "unorthodox" principles and measures for the prospective Turkish campaign and proposed as a general objective that the "ignorance and ferocity of Asians [should be made to] shatter against the art and cold-bloodedness of Europeans."¹⁹

The physical appearance of the Turkish army occasioned early Orientalizing descriptions. The forces that encircled the Russian troops at Stălinești during the Pruth campaign fascinated one of the Russian commanders, the French soldier of fortune Jean Nichole Moreau de Brasey, with their "sunlit jazzy vestments, the glitter of their weapons shining like diamonds, their majestic headwear, and their light, enviable horses." Forming a semicircle around the Russian army, the Ottoman and Tatar troops offered "an ineffable picture," leading him to conclude that "no army is more beautiful, majestic, and splendid than the Turkish."²⁰ The

¹⁶ B. K. Minikh [Burkhard Christoph von Münnich], "Zapiski fel'dmarshala grafa Minikha," in *Perevoroty i voiny*, ed. A. Liberman and V. Naumov (Moscow: Fond Sergeia Dubova, 1997), 273.

¹⁷ A. N. Pushkin, "Vzgliad na voennoe sostoianie Turetskoi imperii," *Syn otechestva* 107, no. 9 (1826): 178.

¹⁸ A. I. Martos, "Otryvok iz pisem russkogo ofitsera," *Syn otechestva* 44 (1819): 166–67.

¹⁹ Pushkin, "Vzgliad na voennoe sostoianie Turetskoi imperii," no. 9, 187.

²⁰ "Zapiski Moro-de-Brasey (kasaiushchiesia do turetskogo pokhoda 1711 g.)," in A. S. Pushkin, *Polnoe sobranie sochinenii*, 16 vols. (Moscow: AN SSSR, 1938), 10:329. The original French

strikingly visual quality of Moreau's description reminds one of the centrality of spectacle in Orientalist discourse. This tendency is even stronger in the late 18th-century Russian account of the meeting of the Russian and Ottoman embassies on the Dniester on their way to Istanbul and St. Petersburg, respectively, to secure the ratification of the Jassy peace treaty of 1792. As the two ambassadorial trains, accompanied by troops, approached the opposite banks of the river,

The one was seen covered with wealth, gold, silver and costly ornaments; while the other exhibited the greatest simplicity and the most martial and impressive appearance. Here everything was in brilliant confusion: Turkish horses, richly caparisoned, covered with housings of immense value, which reached to the ground; mean and beggarly carriages; and the Turks themselves in their Oriental costume and advancing with the greatest irregularity:—There, on the contrary, all was order and propriety; not a step that was not regulated, not a manoeuvre that was not performed with the greatest precision. Deafened as we were with tumult, with hurried cries and the discord of a barbarous music, we preserved the most perfect tranquility and our music was soothing, rich, and delicious.²¹

Much like the changing perception of the Ottoman military, specifically Orientalist descriptions of the Ottoman political system in the Russian accounts emerged only gradually. Initially defined by religious enmity, the early texts about the Turks hardly contained any criticism of the Ottoman political system *per se*, while the sultans' striking successes in the 15th and 16th centuries could even turn their policies into models to follow for Russian rulers. Taking Nestor Iskander's "Tale of the Capture of Tsargrad by the Turks" as his basis, the 16th-century writer Ivan Peresvetov offered an unorthodox interpretation of the fall of Byzantium and the rise of Turkish power.²² In his "Great Petition" to the young Tsar Ivan IV, Peresvetov portrayed the event as not only God's punishment but also a lesson of what might happen in case a ruler failed to instill "truth" in his country, which in Peresvetov's interpretation meant suppressing the boyar opposition and strengthening the army. Speaking in the person

edition is *Mémoires politiques, amusants et satiriques de messire J. N. D. B. C. de Lion, colonel du régiment de dragons de Casanski et brigadier des armées de Sa M. Czarienne*, 3 vols. (Veritopolie: chez Jean Disant-vrai, 1735).

²¹ [Johann Christian Struve,] *Travels in the Crimea: A History of the Embassy from St. Petersburg to Constantinople in 1793* (London: S. Hamilton, 1802), 75–76.

²² Nestor Iskander's mid-15th-century "Tale of the Capture of Tsargrad by the Turks," in *Medieval Russia: A Source Book, 850–1700*, ed. Basil Dmytryshin (Fort Worth: Holt, Rinehart, and Wilson, 1991), 214–21, can perhaps be called the earliest Russian account of the Ottoman Empire, or rather of the circumstances of its foundation; it influenced many subsequent authors. The "Tale" reproduces the standard church interpretation of the fall as God's punishment for Greek apostasy, in which "the Godless Mehmet" was but a weapon of divine retribution.

of the contemporary Moldavian Prince Petru Rareș, Peresvetov praised Sultan Mehmet the Conqueror, "who, although not an Orthodox tsar, arranged what God wills": he appointed salaried judges across his country, collected all judicial fees and other revenues into the treasury, and used the latter to "gladden the heart of the soldiers." He also "endowed the merchants' commerce with a general code."²³ This policy, according to Peresvetov, contrasted with the practice of the last Byzantine emperor and the Russian tsar, both of whom let the nobles grow rich and idle. The implication was clear: to avoid the sad lot of Constantine XI, the young Ivan had to follow Mehmet's example.

Peresvetov's "Great Petition" represents a singular invocation of the sultan's policy as an unambiguous model for the Russian tsar, written at the high tide of Ottoman power and, no less important, presaging the anti-boyar policies of Ivan the Terrible.²⁴ At the moment of its incorporation into the Russian Chronograph of 1617, Peresvetov's account of the "anti-boyar" reforms of Mehmet turned into deeds of the "godless Turks," which was more in accord with the canonical version.²⁵ This "editing" is explained not by the onset of the Ottoman decline detected by contemporary European writers but by Russian internal politics, which in the wake of the Time of Troubles were defined by cooperation between the first Romanov tsar and the boyars.

Reports of Ottoman military and political weakness reached Muscovy very early. Already in 1592, the Russian ambassador Grigorii Afanas'evich Nashchekin wrote that "everything has changed in Turkey. The sultan and the pashas think only about gain.... There is no order or justice in the state. The sultan plunders the officials and the officials plunder the people. Robbery and murder are everywhere, and there is no security for travelers on the roads or for merchants in trade."²⁶ The high representatives of the Greek church hierarchy who visited Russia carried the same message. In 1649, the patriarch of Jerusalem, Paisios, sent a message to Tsar Aleksei Mikhailovich with an invitation to join the Moldavian and Wallachian princes on a campaign to take Istanbul, "for now the strength of the Turk is exhausted."²⁷ After the first Muscovite successes in

²³ I. S. Peresvetov, "Bol'shaia chelobitnaia," in *Biblioteka literatury Drevnei Rusi*, 15 vols., ed. D. S. Likhachev et al. (St. Petersburg: Nauka, 1997–), 9:441. On Peresvetov, see A. V. Karavashkin, *Russkaia srednevekovaia publitsistika* (Moscow: Prometei, 2000), 27–126; and A. A. Zimin, *I. S. Peresvetov i ego sovremenniki* (Moscow: Nauka, 1958).

²⁴ This coincides with positive evaluations of the Ottoman political system, or at least an absence of dismissive attitudes, in the writings of Machiavelli or Jean Bodin.

²⁵ Zimin, *I. S. Peresvetov i ego sovremenniki*, 291.

²⁶ Cited in B. M. Dantsig, *Blizhnii Vostok v russkoi nauke i literature* (Moscow: Nauka, 1973), 28.

²⁷ N. F. Kapterev, *Kharakter otoshenii Rossii k Pravoslavnomu Vostoku v XVI i v XVII stoletiiakh* (Moscow: L. F. Snegirev, 1885), 262–63. The founder of the Bogoiavlenskii Monastery, Arsenii Sukhanov, who traveled across the Ottoman Empire in 1649–53 and again in 1654, added "that

the war against Poland over the Hetmanate, a Greek scholar whom Russians knew as Nikolai Moritskii put forward the idea of an alliance between tsar and hetman to liberate the Christians, "since at present the Turks are weak and have internecine struggles."²⁸ The Greek clergy propagated the idea of Ottoman decline later in the century, when the archimandrite of St. Paul's Monastery on Mount Athos, Isaiah, brought messages to Moscow from the former patriarch of Constantinople Dionysios, Prince Șerban Cantacuzino of Wallachia, and Patriarch Arsenije III of Serbia. On their behalf, Isaiah summoned the Russian tsars Ivan and Peter to a holy war for the liberation of the Orthodox Church and declared that "at present the whole Turkish state has received a harsh punishment from God and the great Muslimhood [*busurmanstvo*] is coming to utter ruin."²⁹

That such reports were not enough to convince the Russians is clear from the fact that in 1644 an Assembly of the Land (*zemskii sobor*), specially convoked by Tsar Mikhail Fedorovich, advised returning Azov, which had been captured by the Cossacks, to the Turks. Highly conscious of their military inferiority, the Muscovites hesitated before deciding upon the alliance with the Hetmanate that was energetically advocated by Patriarch Paisios. The difficulties they encountered in the subsequent war with Poland and the Ottoman Empire only confirmed their fears. It was for this reason that Russian writers of the period were far from concluding that the Ottoman Empire had attained a state of irreversible decline and noticed only the "unorthodox" character of Ottoman internal policy. Thus Andrei Lyzlov wrote that the sultans' exclusive concern with the army led them to abandon their population to the mercy of the soldiers, whose plundering deprived the population of the incentive to cultivate land. Writing of "many vast deserts and emptied territories without number" in the Ottoman domains, Lyzlov specifically contrasted such scarcity of population with the populousness of the German lands. Anticipating the physiocratic doctrines of the 18th century, Lyzlov argued that the "cultivation of land and related activities form the basis of the arts and the latter provide the foundation of commerce; when cultivators are few, everything else is lacking." The domination of commerce by Jews and European Christians is mentioned by the author as another reason for the lack of abundance in the Ottoman state. Nevertheless, Lyzlov's account is restrained in its criticism of Ottoman policies, for although the "revenues of the Turkish sultan are not as great as [what] the greatness of his state ... could

all Christians are envisioning Aleksei Mikhailovich taking Constantinople" (Dantsig, *Blizhnii Vostok*, 32).

²⁸ Kapterev, *Kharakter otnoshenii*, 265.

²⁹ Ibid., 271; see also A. A. Kochiubinskii, *Snosheniia Rossii pri Petre Pervom s iuzhnymi slavianami i rumynami* (Moscow: Universitetskaia tipografiia, 1872), 6–7.

produce," the system of *timars* (conditionally held estates), of which Lyzlov apparently approves, "provides him with a revenue more important than silver."³⁰

The Theme of Ottoman Decline and Its Reception in Russia

Whereas Peresvetov considered the sultans worthy of imitation by the Russian tsar, 18th-century observers found their internal policies to be incompatible with the ideals of a reforming monarchy and of the emperor as serving the state and the well-being of his or her subjects. Mentioning the unwillingness of the Ottomans to engage in war in the wake of the 1699 Treaty of Karlowitz, Peter the Great's ambassador Tolstoi noted that the sultan desired peace for the sake of his own "private amusements" and not because of his "care for his subjects [and] concern for their peaceful living or state building as befits sovereigns." Similarly, all his ministers "cared more about their [own] wealth than about state government": they stole a third of the taxes that were collected, so that only a third of the revenue reached the treasury. (The remaining third traditionally went to religious establishments.)³¹ Reflecting upon the political instability of the Ottoman Empire, Tolstoi wrote that high-ranking dignitaries "make advances to the simple people not out of love but out of fear that they might riot," since the Turks are "prone to state disturbances and rebellion" and "call themselves a free people."³² In a remark that was bound to make Peter the Great recall the recent *strel'tsy* rebellion, Tolstoi mentioned the Janissaries, who "care neither about the sultan, nor about the vezir or any minister" and obeyed only their elected commanders.³³ From a positive political model in the time of Ivan the Terrible, the polity of the sultans by the early 18th century had turned into an anti-model, the very nightmare that the Russian ruler had just escaped but that nevertheless continued to haunt his successors until the end of the century.

In the 18th century, educated Russians could encounter references to the Ottoman decline in Western sources such as published reports by French diplomats about the Janissary rebellions and descriptions of the Ottoman Empire by Paul Rycaut and Luigi Ferdinando Marsigli, both of which were translated into Russian.³⁴ Even more important was the influence of Peter's ally in the

³⁰ Lyzlov, *Skifskaiia istoriia*, 268–70.

³¹ Tolstoi, *Russkii posol v Stambule*, 48–49.

³² *Ibid.*, 38–39.

³³ *Ibid.*, 58.

³⁴ *Izvestie o dvukh vozmushcheniakh, sluchivshikhsia v Konstantinopole 1730 i 1731 goda pri nizlozhenii Akhmeta III i vozvedenii na prestol Magometa* (St. Petersburg, 1738); Luidzhi Marsil'i [Luigi Ferdinando Marsigli], *Voennoe sostoianie Ottomanskoi imperii s ee prirashcheniem i upadkom* (St. Petersburg, 1737); [Paul Rycaut,] *Monarkhiia turetskaia opisannaia cherez byvshego angliiskogo sekretaria posol'stva pri Ottomanskoi Porte. Perevod s pol'skogo* (St. Petersburg, 1741).

unfortunate Pruth campaign, Prince Dimitrie Cantemir of Moldavia, whose posthumous *History of the Growth and Decay of the Othman Empire* received wide European acclaim and remained unsurpassed until the beginning of the 19th century.³⁵ Although a Russian translation of this work did not appear until 1828, Cantemir, who spent the last 12 years of his life in Russia, had ample opportunity to share his views with the tsar and the Russian elite.³⁶ The idea of Ottoman decline that was transmitted through these works arguably had little practical influence, however, as the 1735–39 Russo-Turkish war failed to bring decisive advantage to a Russia whose internal state in the decades following Peter's death was far from stable. It took a long time before the general awareness of disorders in the Ottoman state evolved into a perception that the Ottomans were weak relative to Russia.

Even after the Russian Empire scored an undisputable victory over the Ottomans in 1768–74, there was still some way to go before Turkish weakness was interpreted as a long-term and irreversible decline. Characteristic of this transitional stage were the *Considerations on the Truly Critical State of the Ottoman Porte* by Eugenios Voulgaris ("Bulgari" in Russian), a Greek scholar and educator invited to Russia by Catherine II.³⁷ According to Voulgaris, one could hardly imagine that the Ottoman Empire, "[which was] so formidable and had the power to decide the fate of all Christendom, could so easily be brought to the brink of ruin."³⁸ Writing about Turkish contempt for the sciences, military art, agriculture, and commerce of the Europeans, Voulgaris nevertheless immediately relativized Ottoman inferiority by pointing out that the better part of the European peoples had been in a similar state only a few centuries earlier.

³⁵ Written in Latin in 1716, Cantemir's work was published in English in 1734 (*The History of the Growth and Decay of the Othman Empire*, trans. N. Tindal, 2 vols. [London: James, John, and Paul Knapton, 1734–35]) and again in 1756; French and German editions followed in 1743 and 1744. The Russian edition was an abridged translation from the German; see *Istoriia Turetskogo gosudarstva ot samogo osnovaniia onogo do noveishikh vremen. Perevod s nemetskogo*, 2 parts (Moscow: Universitetskaiia tipografiia, 1828).

³⁶ Cantemir also wrote *Sistema de religione et statu Imperii Turcici* (The System of the Religion and the Condition of the Turkish Empire), which was translated into Russian by Ivan Il'inskii and published as *Kniga Sistima, ili Sostoianie mukhamedanskoi religii* (St. Petersburg, 1722). Cantemir's deviation from the standard religious interpretation of Ottoman rule provoked the ire of the Holy Synod, and it took the tsar's personal intervention to have the work published; see Schimmelpenninck van der Oye, *Russian Orientalism*.

³⁷ On Voulgaris, see A. S. Sturdza, "Eugène Boulgaris et Nicéphore Teotokis, précurseurs du réveil intellectuel et national de la Grèce," in Sturdza, *Oeuvres posthumes religieuses, historiques, philosophiques et littéraires*, 3 vols. (Paris: Dentu, 1858–61), 3:267–311; and Stephen K. Batalden, *Catherine II's Greek Prelate: Eugenios Voulgaris in Russia, 1771–1806* (Boulder, CO: East European Monographs, 1982).

³⁸ *Rassuzhdeniia na deistvitel'no kriticheskoe sostoianie Ottomanskoi Porty* (Moscow: Universitetskaiia tipografiia u N. Novikova, 1780), 4.

Pre-Petrine Russia had itself been a "nation torn by riots, drowning in cruelty and barbarism," that "in a short time adopts a wondrous image, a perfect order and regularity in military affairs, and finally ascends to the highest degree of glory and might, whereby we see that Scythians have acquired the greatness of the Greeks and Romans."³⁹ Voulgaris's rhetorical question was whether the "Turks cannot undergo the same transformation." According to this author, the Turks had noticed the change in the Russian Empire and "consider it a model worthy of imitation that motivates them to reform."⁴⁰ To prove his point, Voulgaris cited a recently published Russian translation of Ibrahim Müttferrika's *Treatise on Tactics*, in which the author argued for the necessity of borrowing European tactics and pointed to the example of Russia under Peter the Great.⁴¹ Although Ottoman successes in the "military art, agriculture, and commerce" could improve the lot of their Christian subjects, such a transformation was not in the best interest of European states. According to Voulgaris, if peace prevailed, "all the wealth of Europe would flow to Turkey," while war "would make Europe feel the heavy weight of a modernized [*obuchennaia*] Turkey more than ever."⁴² In light of such a prospect, the author was scandalized by the support that some Christian powers offered to the Ottoman Empire instead of helping to destroy this "awful colossus." Striking at the heart of the issue, Voulgaris questioned whether the commercial "interests of France should be considered beneficial to all of Europe" and called for a coalition of European states to expel the Ottomans from the continent.⁴³

Such apprehensions notwithstanding, the victory in the war of 1768–74 clearly showed that the Russians had regained their composure after a string of failures or ambiguous successes in the late 17th and the first half of the 18th centuries. After that, victorious wars came to define the Russian experience with Ottoman Turkey, and accounts of successful campaigns appeared alongside the older literary genres devoted to religious pilgrimages and captivity. This change is best reflected in P. A. Levashev's *The Captivity and Sufferings of Russians in Turkey*, written in 1774 and published in 1790. Authored by a chargé d'affaires of the embassy in Istanbul, the text for the most part recounts the misfortunes of Russian diplomatic agents who found themselves

³⁹ Ibid., 51–52.

⁴⁰ Ibid., 52.

⁴¹ Ibid., 62. See *Izobrazhenie taktiki, ili iskusnyi obraz voisk ustanovleniia, obnarodovannoe i napechatannoe v Konstantinople na turetskom iazyke Ibragimom Effendiem Muteferrikom* (St. Petersburg, 1777), after the French edition *Traité de tactique: ou, Méthode artificielle pour l'ordonnance des troupes* (Vienna: J. T. Trattenern, 1769).

⁴² *Rassuzhdeniia*, 19.

⁴³ Ibid., 75, 77–78.

imprisoned at Yedikule at the beginning of the war in 1768. In sharp contrast to this account of captivity as a hostage, however, the preface, added 16 years later, was already written from the position of a victorious great power. Placing the war in a wider historical perspective, Levashev claimed that the Ottoman state "is no longer in the same condition as it was in the time of the glorious sultans Süleyman, Bayezid, Amurat, and Mehmet." The author compared the empire of the sultans to "the great hulk of a deteriorating building that some time ago astonished and frightened spectators by its mere appearance" but which had recently been nearly destroyed by the "Russian Boreas," that is, the north wind. The deterioration was all the clearer, according to Levashev, when it was compared to the situation of Russia, which since the beginning of the 18th century "incessantly ascends to a higher level, while the Ottoman Empire declines hour by hour." Hence Levashev concluded that a new campaign could complete the destruction of the Ottoman Empire that had been started by the previous and the current war.⁴⁴

As perhaps befits a period opened by the *querelle des livres* (quarrel over books), Levashev's thesis rested on a distinction between "ancient" and "modern" Turks. In a manner reminiscent of Peresvetov's treatment of the Ottoman conquest of Constantinople, Levashev offered a favorable characterization of the ancient Turks, who "amid their very cruelty displayed examples of the best civic virtues and greater reason than the Europeans expected from them." The ancient Turks had been "magnanimous, courteous, merciful, just, and could easily put an army of half a million in the field," but their modern descendants, according to Levashev, "are foreign to all that, being predominantly pusillanimous, coarse, cruel, and deceitful." The sultan's revenues were limited, the army not as numerous as it once had been, and "besides [the army] is riotous and disorganized."⁴⁵ Levashev treated with skepticism the belief of "one foreign envoy" to Istanbul that the Ottomans would have conquered Europe if only they had reorganized their army.⁴⁶ According to the Russian diplomat, such a reorganization would have negated the value of the Turks' personal courage and turned them into "animated machines": "Discipline would have taken the place of the fury that arises from their excessive religious zeal and would have weakened [that zeal]. Besides, their laws, the [geographic] situation of their land, and their way of life

⁴⁴ Published in A. A. Vigin et al., eds., *Puteshestviia po Vostoku v epokhu Ekateriny II* (Moscow: Vostochnaia literatura, 1995), 12 n. 1. The original edition of his work was *Plen i stradanie rossiiian u turkov* (St. Petersburg, 1790).

⁴⁵ Levashev, "Tsaregradskie pis'ma," in *Puteshestviia po Vostoku v epokhu Ekateriny II*, 39–40.

⁴⁶ The envoy in question was probably the French ambassador Charles Gravier de Vergennes (1755–68), whose activities precipitated the Russo-Ottoman war of 1768–74 and Levashev's imprisonment in Yedikule.

may prevent the introduction of either political or military changes, neither of which can be effected without the other."⁴⁷

Apart from their role in the representation of Ottoman decline, Levashev's writings also contributed to the Orientalization of the empire of the sultans in another respect. Levashev's five-year stay in Istanbul, which culminated in his imprisonment in Yedikule in 1768, came after more than a decade of diplomatic service in Stockholm, Dresden, Vienna, and Regensburg. In this period, he not only learned the practical aspects of the diplomatic *métier* but also worked on a Russian translation of François Callières's *De la manière de négocier avec les souverains* (How to Negotiate with Sovereigns [1716])—a standard textbook of diplomacy at the time. Levashev's case illustrates the process whereby many Russian nobles became familiar with the emerging international diplomatic culture.⁴⁸ Eighteenth-century diplomacy was Francophone, increasingly aristocratic, and closely linked with royal courts. Its basic operative principles—reciprocity, continuous management of relations between nations, inviolability of diplomatic agents—were ultimately reflected in "certain styles, mores, and intellectual values" shared by the diplomatic agents. Ever since Peter the Great, this international Francophone diplomatic culture had become a source of models for Russia's autocracy and elite. In the course of the 18th century alone, no fewer than 152 young Russian noblemen were sent to study at the famous School of Diplomats at Strasbourg, and an even greater number received their diplomatic education as attachés of the Russian embassies that were established in all European capitals.⁴⁹

In his *Letters from Constantinople*, Levashev dwelt extensively on the difference between Ottoman diplomatic ritual and the norms and practices that Russia had recently come to share with other European countries. The respect and courtesy shown him as a foreign envoy by the local authorities on his way to Istanbul led one to hope that not only would "such gestures of kindness ... continue," but also that the "ambassador will have a pleasant reception and stay at the capital."⁵⁰ As guests of the sultan, however, foreign ministers were not only flattered and coddled but also subjected to numerous "humiliations" before and during their audiences with the vizier or the sultan. Levashev mentions the

⁴⁷ Levashev, "Tsaregradskie pis'ma," 60. In 1774, Levashev also wrote *Kartina ili opisanie vsekh nashestvii na Rossiю tatar i turkov* (St. Petersburg, 1792) to "incite compatriots to pay greater attention than before to these savage, but numerous and very harmful," adversaries.

⁴⁸ See Vigin et al., eds., *Puteshestviia po Vostoku v epokhu Ekateriny II*, 9–10.

⁴⁹ Hamish Scott, "Diplomatic Culture in Old Regime Europe," in *Cultures of Power in Europe in the Long Eighteenth Century*, ed. Hamish Scott and Brendan Simms (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 2007), 58–85.

⁵⁰ Levashev, "Tsaregradskie pis'ma," 52.

requirement that a foreign ambassador don special pelisses and kaftans, the miserable rooms where he was kept waiting before the audience, the uncomfortable furniture on which he had to sit, the long hours that he had to spend observing the dispensation of justice by Ottoman officials before being admitted to see the sultan, and the food that he had to eat after it had passed through the hands of a servitor who used his own nails to tear morsels of meat.⁵¹ The hodgepodge of hospitality and humiliation to which foreign envoys were subjected was spiced with a sense of physical danger. Lacking permanent representatives of their own in foreign capitals and hence not fearing reprisals, the "Turks not only never showed respect to Christian ministers but in fact mistreated, tortured, and killed many of them." According to Levashev, European ambassadors declined to describe all the humiliations that they underwent in Istanbul "out of national pride and personal vanity." The arrogance of the Ottomans was further abetted by the restraint of the European courts and their failure to follow Russia's hard line on the question of gifts and other matters of diplomatic etiquette.⁵² After a list of French, Dutch, Austrian, and Russian diplomatic agents who were mistreated by the Ottomans, Levashev concluded that "their way of thinking and behavior is completely different from that of other nations, especially the European ones." Hence, for all its intrinsic superiority, the Christian manner of reasoning was a poor guide to dealing with the Ottomans.⁵³

By the end of the 18th century, two elements stood out as manifestations of the "otherness" of the Ottoman Empire in Russian accounts: the failure of the sultans to adopt European military organization, which led to the decline of Ottoman power; and their stubborn attachment to the diplomatic rituals of their bygone age of greatness. By contrast, Russia emerged from these accounts as a country that had successfully mastered international standards of warfare and diplomacy. Such standards had indeed emerged by the second half of the 18th century and were increasingly central to the system of great powers.⁵⁴ The term itself was defined only in the 19th century, but already before 1789, the great powers, or rather the system governing how they functioned, had become a reality in military, political, and cultural terms.⁵⁵ The

⁵¹ Ibid., 52–55. See also [Ia. I. Bulgakov,] *Rossiskoe posol'stvo v Konstantinopole* (St. Petersburg: Pri Imperatorskoi akademii nauk, 1777), as well as Struve's *Travels in the Crimea*, 175–81.

⁵² Levashev, "Tsaregradskie pis'ma," 56–57.

⁵³ Ibid., 59.

⁵⁴ Hamish Scott, *The Birth of the Great Power System, 1740–1815* (London: Pearson Longman, 2006).

⁵⁵ See, for example, Ranke's essay "Great Powers" (1833), in Leopold von Ranke, *The Theory and Practice of History*, ed. and intro. George G. Iggers and Konrad von Moltke (New York: Bobbs-Merrill, 1973), 65–101.

French revolutionary wars represented a temporary disruption in this process. Napoleon's bid for dominance denied the principles of the system and was pursued through the destruction of its individual elements. In the end, however, the system was even more powerfully reasserted at the Congress of Vienna, which created a European concert of five great powers and formalized the relations among them. The exclusion of the Ottoman Empire from this concert was an important aspect of its Orientalization in an age when great-power status became central to a country's "Europeanness." When the system was formalized, the implicit assumption emerged that Ottoman Turkey was less than a great power, albeit still a crucial element of the European balance.

Russia's situation was the exact opposite of the Ottoman Empire's. Russia's ascent to greatness and Ottoman Turkey's Orientalization were in fact two sides of the same process, yet Russia's transformation into a great power remained incomplete. Being a full-fledged member of the European concert since its foundation in 1815, Russia was also increasingly perceived as a threat to the balance of power. Russia's growing strength vis-à-vis the Ottoman Empire, which in the late 18th century had helped it enter the "club," started to suggest that Russia had grown too large to be a "normal" great power. The perceived imbalance that Russia introduced into the European system came at a time when the notion of "great power" was being defined both legally and theoretically. For that reason, the "Russian menace to Europe" was conceptualized differently from earlier Spanish or French bids to dominate the continent. Besides, as the century progressed, the concept of "great power" gradually shed its old-regime connotations and was appropriated by liberal discourse.⁵⁶ As a result, the period between the Congress of Vienna and the Crimean War witnessed a peculiar Orientalization of the Russian Empire in Western, especially French and British, accounts.⁵⁷ An analysis of Russian perceptions of Ottoman Turkey after 1815 must take this factor into consideration.

Borrowed Idioms

The development of the Russian periodical press in the early 19th century played an important part in the process of Orientalizing Ottoman Turkey, in two respects. First, unlike the sporadic reporting about Turkey in the previous century, *Vestnik Evropy*, *Syn otechestva*, and later *Moskovskii telegraf* gave their readers a continuous close-up view of events in the neighboring empire just as

⁵⁶ Iver Neuman, "Rossiiskoe stremlenie k velikoderzhaviiu: Kak Rossiia dobivalas' priznaniia Evropy," *Nasledie imperii i budushchee Rossii*, ed. A. I. Miller (Moscow: Novoe literaturnoe obozrenie, 2008), 139–85.

⁵⁷ Martin Malia, *Russia under Western Eyes: From the Bronze Horseman to the Lenin Mausoleum* (Cambridge, MA: Harvard University Press, 1999), 85–160.

its relative stability gave way to a deep crisis. This crisis was marked by the revolts of Pasvanoglu and Bayraktar Mustafa Pasha, the Janissary rebellions, the deposition of Selim III, the Wahhabi wars, the exploits of Ali Pasha of Janina, the Greek uprising, and Mahmud II's desperate struggle to hold the empire together. Commenting on these developments, Karamzin's *Vestnik Evropy* concluded that the "Ottoman Empire has truly lived out its lifespan."⁵⁸ Second, instead of the unabridged translations typical of the earlier period, 19th-century periodicals often published selected excerpts from Western travelogues and scholarly works.⁵⁹ This substantially increased the number of foreign authors accessible to Russian readers and at the same time introduced a new element of political considerations into the selection of particular fragments for publication. Western perceptions of the Ottoman decline were thus refracted through a Russian filter. The borrowing of Western Orientalist idioms was a highly ambiguous practice. On the one hand, it constituted an important source of rhetorical devices and information for Russian authors writing about the Ottoman Empire and served to create cultural distance and thereby legitimize Russia's aggressive policy in the south. On the other hand, the Western writings about the Ottoman Empire occasionally demonstrated to Russian readers that their own country was only incompletely recognized as a European power. Orientalist idioms could be used not only to carve out a space for a Russian "civilizing mission" but also to articulate Russia's own persistent marginality. In this sense, the Orientalization of the Ottoman Empire revealed the limits of Russia's own integration into the "Occident."

The autocratic character of Russia's own political system explains why the critique of the formally unlimited power of the sultans played a minor role in representations of Ottoman civilizational marginality. If anything, the picture that Russian readers could form on the basis of the selected fragments from Western Orientalist authors published in Russian journals suggested that the Ottoman decline resulted from the *limitations* imposed on the sultan's power by the weight of tradition. Thus a piece called "On the Present Situation of the Turkish State" in *Vestnik Evropy* compared the sultan to a "soulless figure brought into motion by hidden springs, whose every word and motion is prescribed and whose every action, down to the least important, has to be in conformity with the rules." Following the "law codes and the advice of the clergy

⁵⁸ Karamzin argued that with the dissolution of the Ottoman Empire, a "true and easy way to Asia will be opened to European enlightenment." See "O vnutrennem polozenii Turtsii," *Vestnik Evropy* 6, no. 14 (1802): 157–58.

⁵⁹ Those not cited below include William Wittman's *Travels in Turkey, Asia-Minor, Syria, and across the Desert into Egypt* (1803), Antoine-François Andréossy's *Voyage à l'embouchure de la Mer-Noire* (1813), and Ranke's *Fürsten und Völker von Süd-Europa* (1827).

and the Janissaries in all his actions," the sultan, according to this journal, was a "slave like no other in the world."⁶⁰ Far from having "positive consequences for the nation's liberty and well-being," the power of the ulema and the Janissaries, according to a fragment from Juchereau de St. Denys's *L'Histoire de l'Empire Ottoman* (History of the Ottoman Empire [1844]) that was published in *Syn otechestva*, was the "main and perhaps the only cause of the empire's decline as well as of the ignorance and barbarism of its people." The ulema rejected "enlightenment and science out of fear that it could inspire contempt for the Koran," whereas the Janissaries "are accustomed to idle service and loathe strict European discipline"; both together "prevent the Ottoman Empire from joining the ranks of the European powers and adopting their useful discoveries and military institutions."⁶¹ Failing to recognize the true reasons for their military defeats and to adopt the military organization common among European peoples, the "sultans," the translation continued, "will soon see their armies annihilated, Rumelia occupied, Constantinople threatened, and the Greeks armed against them."⁶²

At the same time, Western authors were not unanimous in their interpretation of the Ottoman decline. Indicative of the variety of opinions is Conrad Malte-Brun's *An Overview of the Greatness and Decay of the Ottoman Empire*, excerpts of which were published in *Vestnik Evropy* in 1822.⁶³ For Malte-Brun, the decay of Turkey resulted not from the character of Islam, which his contemporary Louis de Bonald deemed "at variance with nature and human society," but rather from the failure of the Turks "to introduce the spirit of the Koran into their institutions, where the military aspect has always suppressed the political."⁶⁴ This failure rendered the military despotism that had brought Ottoman power to its height internally unstable and explained its current weakness. Malte-Brun's work also shows that the perspectives of French writers on the future of Ottoman Turkey could be as different as their explanations for its sorry present state. In a passage that was omitted in the Russian translation, Malte-Brun claimed that "the Ottoman Empire is still capable of a long and even

⁶⁰ "O nyneshnem sostoianii Turtsii," *Vestnik Evropy* 89, no. 20 (1816): 295. The passage was taken from *Travels of Ali Bey in Morocco, Tripoli, Cyprus, Egypt, Arabia, Syria, and Turkey*, 2 vols. (Philadelphia: James Maxwell, 1816); the book's true author was Domingo Badia y Leblich (1766–1818), a Spanish explorer who adopted a Muslim identity (Ali Bei al-Abbassi) to facilitate his travels through the Muslim world.

⁶¹ "Otryvki o Turtsii," *Syn otechestva* 74, no. 49 (1821): 102–3.

⁶² *Ibid.*, 112.

⁶³ See "Stat'ia o Turtsii iz Parizha," *Vestnik Evropy* 121, no. 20 (1821): 302–8. The original is [Conrad] Malte-Brun, "Aperçus sur la grandeur et la décadence de l'Empire Ottoman," in *Nouvelles annales des voyages, de la géographie et de l'histoire* 11 (1821): 284–327.

⁶⁴ "Stat'ia o Turtsii iz Parizha," 306.

imposing existence," especially if the weakness of the separatist pashas and the enmity among its Christian subjects could be exploited by an able administrator like Peter the Great or Frederick the Great.⁶⁵

Russian press coverage of the destruction of the Janissary corps by Mahmud II in 1826 provides an interesting illustration of how selectively Russians cited Western Orientalist texts. Following an already established practice, *Syn otechestva* published fragments from Charles Deval's *Deux années à Constantinople et en Morée* (Two Years in Constantinople and Morea [1827]) to inform its readers about the dramatic events unfolding in the Ottoman capital and in rebellious Greece. Deval referred to the event as a "terrible massacre" and compared it to the extermination of the *strel'tsy* by Peter the Great and the more recent destruction of the Mameluks by Mahmud II's Egyptian vassal Muhammad Ali.⁶⁶ The Russian translation, however, omitted Deval's characterization of these cases as "great coups d'état that could not be executed among civilized peoples [*chez des peuples policés*] and that can take place only among barbarous nations, where the orders of the prince, just or unjust, are implemented on the spot with blind submission."⁶⁷ As this and the previous example demonstrate, Russian translators and editors were aware that the rhetorical devices adopted by them to Orientalize the Ottoman Empire could also be applied to Russia with the same goal. In these conditions, an implicit contrast between a declining Turkey and an ascendant Russia structured the Russian discourse, along with the censoring of any explicit comparisons between the empires that could be advantageous to the Ottomans and disadvantageous to Russia.

By rendering a new Russo-Ottoman war imminent, the Greek uprising of 1821 contributed to the further Orientalization of the Ottoman Empire and, at the same time, revealed the ambivalence of Russia's position in Europe. Translated Western commentaries on the Greek crisis fed into the general image of Ottoman Turkey as a stagnant despotic power. Thus *Vestnik Evropy* published the opinion of Louis de Bonald, otherwise a leading legitimist writer, about the illegitimacy of the Ottoman Empire in Europe. It had failed, he wrote, "to bring peace, civic freedom, and political equality between the people who rule and the people who are ruled," and as a result, one could see "neither that benevolence" on the part of the Turks, "nor that assurance of their rights" on the part of the Greeks, "nor that mutual affection on both sides that after three and a half centuries of living under the same government should link the two peoples and turn

⁶⁵ Malte-Brun, "Aperçus sur la grandeur," 300, 327.

⁶⁶ "Dva goda v Konstantinopole i Moree," *Syn otechestva* 117, no. 3 (1828): 302.

⁶⁷ Charles Deval, *Deux années à Constantinople et en Morée* (1825–26) (Paris: Nepveu, 1827), 107.

them into a single nation."⁶⁸ For de Bonald, the Ottoman Empire was therefore not a "legitimate society" but a "military camp" in Europe, which justified an intervention by the Christian powers on behalf of the Greeks.

The Russian translation omitted, however, de Bonald's point that one need not fear the prospect of a Russian capture of Istanbul in case of such an intervention, since Russian rulers who established themselves on the Bosphorus, would soon, by the very nature of things, become independent of St. Petersburg. (De Bonald had in mind the "Greek project" of Catherine II, which proposed the appointment of her second grandson Constantine as emperor of a new Greek empire with its capital in Constantinople.) What seems to have motivated this omission was de Bonald's thesis that "Russia, although strong by its climate, its [large] population, its deserts, the enlightenment of its government, and even the ignorance of its population, can today be contained, like all great empires, like the great empire of Bonaparte, only by itself, and like an immense river it can only grow weaker by extending itself."⁶⁹ The comparison with the Napoleonic empire shows the limits of Russia's integration into the European system of great powers that became apparent in the course of the Greek crisis. It is remarkable that the comparison served not to illustrate "Russia's menace to Europe" but to predict the eventual results of its expansion. Eight years later, when Russian troops marched to Adrianople, the same idea was stated even more explicitly by Charles MacFarlane in his *Constantinople in 1828*.⁷⁰ According to this British author, "the vast empire of the Czars,—a collection of the multitudinous parts rather than a great whole,—feels already within itself the symptoms of disseverance."⁷¹ Anticipating its inevitable reduction "to a discreet and compatible size," MacFarlane argued that the extension of the Russian Empire to Turkey would only hasten this process.⁷² As one might expect, this

⁶⁸ "O Turtsii," *Vestnik Evropy* 121, no. 19 (1821): 211.

⁶⁹ De Bonald, "Sur la Turquie," *Journal des Débats* (20 September 1821), 3.

⁷⁰ A British naval officer and participant in the destruction of the Ottoman fleet at Navarino in late 1827 by the combined British, French, and Russian squadrons, MacFarlane was a resident of the Ottoman capital during the Russo-Ottoman war that followed.

⁷¹ MacFarlane related this process to the "improvement, which however slowly it advances, is advancing already in its semi-barbarous domains"; see Charles MacFarlane, *Constantinople in 1828*, 2 vols. (London: Saunders and Otley, 1829), 2:328. Interestingly, MacFarlane's French translator rendered "improvement" as "civilization"; see Charles MacFarlane, *Constantinople et la Turquie en 1828*, 3 vols., trans. Alfred François Nettement (Paris: Moutardier, 1829–30), 3:18.

⁷² To prove his point, MacFarlane pointed to the attempt by Louis XIV to unite the French and Spanish domains under the rule of the Bourbons: despite Louis's strenuous efforts to secure the Spanish throne for his grandson Philip, "[in] a few years the Bourbon prince was identified with the Spanish nation, his descendants became intrinsically Spanish" (*Constantinople in 1828*, 3:19–20).

passage was not among those published by *Vestnik Evropy* soon after MacFarlane work's appeared in both English and French editions.⁷³

The years leading up to the Russo-Ottoman war of 1828–29 witnessed a proliferation of Russian descriptions of the Ottoman Empire. Making abundant use of Western sources, these descriptions articulated a characteristically Orientalizing perception that combined the idea of the Turks' cultural marginality within Europe with a belief in the inevitability of their expulsion into Asia. Implicitly or explicitly concerned with the cultural marginality of their own country, Russian authors took every opportunity to stress the marginality of the Turks and cited or plagiarized Western writers to that purpose. Thus Ivan Gur'ianov, an author of unsophisticated descriptions of the Ottoman Empire, defined Turks as the descendants of those "wild Asiatic peoples that, having no settlement, considered every country their own and went from one place to another."⁷⁴ The author of *A Historical and Political Description of the Ottoman Porte*, Sergei Nikolaevich Glinka, cited Herder's diatribes against the Turks, in which the German philosopher bemoaned the destruction of numerous works of art and the reduction of the Greeks to slavery. Agreeing with Herder, Glinka compared the Ottoman Empire to "a vast prison for all the Europeans who dwell in it" and expressed the conviction that it would fall eventually, "for what business do foreigners have in Europe, who, after a lapse of a thousand years, are still determined to remain Asiatic barbarians!"⁷⁵ In another work, Glinka cited the extremely popular travelogue by Robert Walsh, who, upon seeing "the actual state of this fine country—its resources neglected, its fields lying waste, its towns in ruins, its population decaying," came to the conclusion that the "sleeping lion," to which he compared the Ottoman Empire, "did not sleep, but was dying, and after a few violent convulsions will never rise again."⁷⁶

Plagiarizing from de Bonald, the anonymous author of *A Historical, Statistical, and Political Overview of the Ottoman Porte* stressed the failure of

⁷³ See Sharl' Mak-Farlan [Charles MacFarlane], "O prichinakh nyneshnego polozheniia Turtsii," *Vestnik Evropy* 168, no. 17 (1829): 63–67.

⁷⁴ Ivan Gur'ianov, *Russkii v Tsar'grade ili istoricheskoe, topograficheskoe i statisticheskoe obozrenie Konstantinopolia i ego okrestnostei* (Moscow: Universitetskaia tipografiia, 1828), 33.

⁷⁵ *Kartina istoricheskaiia i politicheskaiia Porty Ottomanskoi* (Moscow: Stepanov, 1830), 25–26; John Godfrey Herder, *Outlines of a Philosophy of the History of Man*, 2nd ed., 2 vols. (London: Luke Hanford, 1803), 2:355.

⁷⁶ *Obozrenie vnutrennosti Turtzii Evropeiskoi pocherpnutoe iz drevnikh i novykh pisatelei* (Moscow: Reshetnikov, 1829), 9–10, citing Robert Val'sh, *Puteshestvie po Turtzii iz Konstantinopolia v Angliiu cherez Venu* (St. Petersburg: Tipografiia Vdovy Pliushar, 1829), 189–90. The Russian edition was translated from the French (Robert Walsh, *Voyage en Turquie et Constantinople* [Paris: Moutardier, 1828], 168–69), which in its turn was translated from the original English edition: Robert Walsh, *Narrative of a Journey from Constantinople to England* (London: Frederick Westley and A. H. Davis, 1828), 221. I quote the original English edition.

the Turks to absorb European influences despite centuries of presence on the continent: "Only these barbarians, despite having conquered many enlightened peoples, could mix with their captives without adopting their language, faith, enlightenment, and customs."⁷⁷ The fact that the "descendants of Leonidas, Themistocles, and Epaminondas suffer from the yoke of an unknown people" in the "sacred homeland of faith and freedom" appeared to the author all the more unnatural at a time when "the European has established his glory and might, has spread enlightenment and education on the banks of the Ganges and the Anadyr, the Río de la Plata and the Mississippi, on the Cape of Good Hope and beyond the Blue Mountains of [New] South Wales."⁷⁸ Unambiguously inscribing the Russians among the Europeans, the author of the *Description* expressed a firm conviction that the Ottoman strongholds "will not be able to resist the valiant Sons of the North for any length of time."⁷⁹

An Ottoman Peter the Great?

A special stress on the Turks' marginality in Europe was not the only peculiarity of the Russian discourse on the Ottoman Empire in the early 19th century. Besides the desire to prove autocratic Russia's "Europeanness" by assigning it a "civilizing mission" in the "Orthodox East," the Orientalization of Turkey was also conditioned by the latter's internal political transformations. The portrayal of the Ottoman decline as a manifestation of perennial Oriental immobility and stagnation in fact coincided with the early attempts by Ottoman rulers to follow European models. This placed their empire in a situation not unlike Russia in the late 17th century. The parallels between Selim III's *nizam-ı cedid* (new order) or Mahmud II's destruction of the Janissaries, on the one hand, and Peter's "play regiments" and the crushing of the *strel'tsy* rebellion, on the other, were impossible to miss and threatened to relativize the civilizational gap between the polities that the Russian descriptions sought to create.⁸⁰ The reaction of Russian

⁷⁷ *Istoricheskoe, statisticheskoe i politicheskoe obozrenie Porty Ottomanskoi* (Moscow: Stepanov, 1829), 4–5.

⁷⁸ *Ibid.*, 5.

⁷⁹ *Ibid.*, 64–65.

⁸⁰ The parallel between the Janissaries and the Russian *strel'tsy* can be traced to Voltaire, *L'Histoire de la Russie sous Pierre le Grand*, 2 vols. (Paris: Librairie de la Bibliothèque Nationale, 1880), 1:45–46. Westernization of dress was another aspect of juxtaposition between the tsar and the sultan. Some observers, including Napoleon's Marshal Auguste de Marmont, found that the new demi-kaftans, fezzes, and narrow pants lacked the majesty of traditional Oriental vestments. See his *Voyage du maréchal duc de Raguse*, 4 vols. (Paris: L'advocat, 1837); Russian edition *Puteshestviia Marshala Marmona, Gertsoga Raguzskogo*, 2 vols. (Moscow: Stepanov, 1840–41), 2:46. Others defended the adoption of European fashions by the "brave reformer of the Orient." According to Alphonse Rouillet, the criticism leveled at Mahmud II for the change of dress was all the more unjust since "nobody blamed [Peter the Great] for the fact that the Russians shaved their beards and

observers was to stress the futility of any attempts at Westernization undertaken by the sultans and to underline the superficiality of their results. Meanwhile, the growing uncertainty about Russia's own relationship with Europe introduced ambiguity into the Russian discourse about Ottoman reforms. As the idea of the corruption of popular mores by the vices of civilization transpired through the Russian criticism of Turkish hostility to enlightenment, the Orientalization of the Ottoman Empire increasingly entailed a condemnation of the pernicious moral consequences of Turkey's Westernization.

Russian writers were not unanimous in their assessment of the attempts by Mahmud II to transform the Ottoman Empire and imitate European institutions and practices. A sympathetic attitude was expressed by the Russian consul in Syria and Palestine, Konstantin Bazili, who claimed that a "great revolution is being accomplished in a great neighboring empire: a monarch with an iron will shakes off prejudices that lie like soot on his obsolescent empire and avidly searches for the elements of new life."⁸¹ This author compared the sultan to Samson in that in his quest to destroy a "whole edifice of popular beliefs," he risked perishing under its debris. Leaving it to history to judge Mahmud's deeds, Bazili argued nevertheless that the sultan exhibited all the main qualities of a reformer—"willpower, self-renunciation, and noble intentions." His description of the titanic struggle of Mahmud II against traditionalism could not fail to remind Russian readers of Peter the Great. Viewed from another perspective, the destruction of the Janissaries in 1826, which "opened the way for popular well-being," looked very much like the suppression of the *strel'tsy* rebellion.

Overall, however, Russian commentators remained skeptical and stressed the faults of Mahmud II's policies: the shortcomings of the new Ottoman army, the failures of the reform of local administration, and the impact of the sultan's Westernization on the moral state of the Turkish population. According to the Russian periodical *Moskovskii telegraf*, the destruction of the Janissary corps was necessary, but it was accomplished at a most inopportune moment: "In time of peace, he could have unswervingly pursued his goals, but amid war ... the reforms only sapped the moral strength of the people without increasing its military capacities."⁸² According to a participant of the 1828–29 war, the army physician Karl Seidlitz, the Ottomans were led to defeat not by "their ignorance of European military science but by a loss of valor. The latter was killed by modern military exercises that were imposed on them, and which they consider senseless

clipped their long caftans in order to become Europeans"; see "Sultan Makhmud i ego ministry," *Syn otechestva* 4 (vtoroe dvadtsatipiatiletie), no. 3 (1838): 66.

⁸¹ Konstantin Bazili, *Ocherki Konstantinopolia*, 2 vols. (St. Petersburg: Grech, 1835), 1:69.

⁸² "Istoricheskii i statisticheskii vzgliad na poslednee desiatiletie Turtsii," *Moskovskii telegraf*, no. 14 (1832): 262.

and unnecessary.”⁸³ In his *Travels across Southern Russia, Crimea, and Odessa to Constantinople* (1839), the Russian publisher and historian N. S. Vsevolozhskii described the new Ottoman soldiers as poorly dressed and sometimes barefooted teenagers who knew “neither cleanliness nor training.”⁸⁴ He questioned the claims of Ottoman commanders that Peter the Great had likewise had a poor start before eventually defeating his vanquisher.⁸⁵ According to Vsevolozhskii, the string of victorious Russian commanders from Münnich to Paskevich was a product of the invitation of foreigners into Russian service that was started by the reforming tsar. In the Ottoman case, however, this outcome was precluded by the requirement of religious conversion as well as the usual contempt with which the Ottomans treated renegades.⁸⁶

While they focused primarily on Mahmud’s military policies, Russian critics also commented on the sultan’s attempts to reform local administration. In his *Review of the Present State of Asia Minor*, the military geographer Mikhail Vronchenko argued that with the destruction of the Janissaries, the “population has lost the last support against the rapaciousness of the local administration, without gaining a new one in the form of justice and solicitude from the supreme government.” The destruction of the old provinces (*sanjak*) and the subsequent reorganization of the empire into smaller administrative units created a chaos of conflicting jurisdictions and left the system of tax farming as the only stable element among Ottoman institutions.⁸⁷ While praising the traditional

⁸³ “Iz vospominanii doktora Zeidlitsa,” *Russkii arkhiv* 2, no. 5 (1878): 110.

⁸⁴ N. S. Vsevolozhskii, *Puteshestvie cherez Iuzhnuuiu Rossiiu, Krym i Odessu v Konstantinopol’, Maluiu Aziuu, Severnuuiu Afriku, Mal’tu, Sitsiliuu, Italiuu, Iuzhnuuiu Frantsiiu i Parizh* (Moscow: Avgust Semen, 1839), 267. Marmont described the new Ottoman army as hastily assembled and poorly trained—a “motley crowd of miserable and timid people” commanded by officers “who lacked abilities and talents” (*Puteshestviia Marshala Marmona, Gertsoga Raguzskogo*, 2:63). By contrast, an article in the *British Chronicle*, republished in Russian as “Vzgliad na vnutrennee sostoianie Turetskoi Imperii,” *Vestnik Evropy* 166, no. 12 (1829): 298, cited approvingly the growing numbers of the new Ottoman army.

⁸⁵ Vsevolozhskii, *Puteshestvie*, 267. Marmont was skeptical about Mahmud’s ability to emulate the tsar-reformer, whose success, in Marmont’s opinion, was due to the fact that unlike the sultan, he “was uninvolved in the political affairs of Europe” and dealt with a people who formed a “homogenous mass” (*Puteshestviia Marshala Marmona*, 2:96).

⁸⁶ Vsevolozhskii, *Puteshestvie*, 268–69.

⁸⁷ M. Vronchenko, *Obozrenie Maloi Azii v nyneshnem ee sostoianii*, 2 vols. (St. Petersburg: Karl Krai, 1839–40), 1:247. *Puteshestviia Marshala Marmona*, 2:89–90, criticizes the abolition of the timars and claims that the reform of local administration had been a failure as the “new officials appointed by the sultan lacked the authority that the lords of estates used to have over the people.” Other Western observers praised Mahmud II’s measures against the separatist *derebeys* (lords of the valley). The abovementioned *British Chronicle* claimed that the “situation of Turkey became different after Mahmud II abolished all hereditary immunities and governorships (*pashalyks*) and started to govern them directly” (translated from the Russian version in “Vzgliad na vnutrennee sostoianie

noble moral qualities of the Turks, Vronchenko attributed the longevity of the Ottoman Empire to an "exemplary" judicial system that was in accordance with the people's way of thinking and living. According to Vronchenko, "[nowadays] the people regret the disappearance of these qualities, the corruption of the judges, and oppression by the governors."⁸⁸ He noted that with the reestablishment of the sultan's control over Anatolia, the life of the individual had become almost as secure as in European states, yet paradoxically, the "people were not particularly grateful to the sultan for this."⁸⁹

The lukewarm support of Western observers for Mahmud's policies was a common theme for Russian authors, who presented the Westernizing reforms as incompatible with Turkish popular mores and customs. Vsevolozhskii portrayed all improvements in Turkey as products of the sultan's personal convictions, whereas "people are indifferent to everything, immobile in their notions, and do not want to understand the goals of these new inventions."⁹⁰ Failing to win popular support, the Westernizing policies of Mahmud II had a corrupting impact on the traditional moral qualities of the Turks. The Russian envoy in Istanbul in 1832–33, N. N. Murav'ev-Karskii, remarked that "debauchery [is] being introduced in Turkey together with reforms."⁹¹ What good he found in contemporary Turkey existed not because of the reforming sultan's efforts but in spite of them. According to Murav'ev, "people, however, still preserve their old-time qualities—honesty and righteousness—and while ill-conceived innovations destroy the purity of popular mores, the deep appreciation for justice has not yet been effaced from their hearts."⁹²

Even the generally sympathetic Bazili granted that the reforms were at odds with the spirit of the people. In a continuation of his *Essays on Constantinople*, he told readers of his encounter with a young Ottoman naval officer in an Istanbul library. In response to Bazili's comment that reading foreign newspapers was much more useful than endlessly copying the Koran, the Turk complained that

Turetskoi imperii," 298). According to Alphonse Rouillet ("Sultan Makhmud i ego ministry," 80), the derebays were not unlike French feudal lords: "After Mahmud has suppressed them, only Muhammad Ali (the ruler of Egypt) opposes his sovereign, just as the duke of Burgundy opposed Louis XI." Naturally, such comparisons were supposed to leave French (and the Russian) readers with little doubt as to Mahmud's eventual success.

⁸⁸ Vsevolozhskii, *Puteshestvie*, 261–62.

⁸⁹ Ibid., 267.

⁹⁰ Ibid., 271. See also Marmont's remark that Mahmud's imitation of Christian institutions and practices alienated Muslims, who no longer "religiously venerate the descendant of the Ottomans" (*Puteshestviia Marshala Marmona*, 2:90).

⁹¹ See, respectively, Vsevolozhskii, *Puteshestvie*, 270; and N. N. Murav'ev-Karskii, *Turtsiia i Egipt v 1832 i 1833 gg.*, 4 vols. (Moscow: Mamontov, 1869), 1:6.

⁹² Ibid.

an "infatuation with foreign education will condemn our authentic [*korennoi*] national learning to oblivion." The officer wondered rhetorically whether forgetting the learning of one's fathers was the first condition of educational progress in European states. Meanwhile, Mahmud's Turkey was precisely in such a dangerous situation: "The tree of the new knowledge planted by the Sultan is still too young and will not bear fruit soon, [while] the venerable tree of ancient learning is already decaying." Given the "insurmountable barrier of religion and nationality [*narodnost*]" separating the Ottoman Empire from Europe, Bazili's interlocutor insisted that the "reformer's first concern should be to support this nationality," and that the best way to educate Turkey was by improving its native Muslim institutions of learning.⁹³

It is remarkable that Bazili, as well as other Russian observers of the 1830s, criticized Mahmud II precisely for the attempt to imitate European military art and technology, the ignorance of which figured so prominently in early accounts of Ottoman decline. A slight sense of *déjà vu* would also probably visit anyone familiar with Rousseau's *On the Social Contract*, which criticized Peter the Great for "wishing at once to make Germans and Englishmen, when he should have commenced by making Russians." No less noteworthy is Bazili's decision to articulate his criticism through the fictional figure of a "young" rather than an "old" Turk. The defense of Turkish "nationality" was articulated by someone familiar with European culture, just as the Russian concept of Official Nationality was formulated three years earlier by a Russian minister of enlightenment, Sergei Uvarov, who thought and wrote in French. Thus the opposition between the positive traditional qualities of the Turks and the vices of civilization that emerged in Russian accounts of the Ottoman Empire during the 1830s reflected a change in the Europe-oriented identity of the Russian regime and the educated public.

The Critique of Mimicry

The relevance of the Petrine approach to modernization to the policies of Mahmud II was apparent not only to Western or Russian commentators, for there is some evidence that the Ottomans were themselves looking at Russia as a model. Ibrahim Mütefferika's *Treatise on Tactics* may have been a lonely voice in the desert at the moment of its publication in the mid-18th century, but by the 1830s the sultan had no other option than to learn from the enemy. Russian visitors to Istanbul knew this and did not hesitate to flatter the Ottomans on their achievements to gain their favor, while confining criticism to

⁹³ Konstantin Bazili, *Bosfor i novye ocherki Konstantinopolia*, 2 vols. in 1 (St. Petersburg: Grech, 1836), 2:225–26.

their writings. To obtain an audience with the sultan and satisfy his curiosity, the traveler Vsevolozhskii told Governor-General Ahmet Pasha that the main goal of his visit to Istanbul was "to see the great sovereign, reformer of this nation, who follows the example of Peter the Great," after which he was immediately received by Mahmud II.⁹⁴ This anecdote indicates the degree, to which mimicry of Occidental models came to structure the encounters between Russians and Ottomans in this period. As a consequence, the critique of such mimicry emerged as an important strategy for Orientalizing the Ottoman Empire in Russian descriptions.⁹⁵

Nikolai Murav'ev-Karskii's memoirs of the diplomatic mission to Istanbul and Alexandria that he undertook at the height of Mahmud II's confrontation with Muhammad Ali in 1833 offers one of the best illustrations of this pattern. Seeking to support the faltering power of the sultan and secure Russian influence in the Ottoman Empire, Murav'ev met with a number of Ottoman dignitaries and was able to observe the new troops created by the sultan after the destruction of the Janissary corps. Murav'ev's first audience was with the *serasker* (war minister), who met him dressed in a soldier's frockcoat and an overcoat, prompting Murav'ev to remark that "while introducing regularity [*reguliarnost'*] among their troops, the Turks have failed to note that officers do not wear soldiers' overcoats and frockcoats."⁹⁶ The *serasker's* behavior during the conversation only confirmed Murav'ev's impression of the clumsiness of Ottoman "Westernization." When he noticed the Russian envoy's interest in the weapons hanging from the walls, the *serasker* boasted of his knowledge of the manual of rifle practice and twice presented arms with a rifle. According to Murav'ev, "one could not imagine anything funnier than the figure of this ugly old man standing at guards."⁹⁷

On his way back from the *serasker*, Murav'ev entered a guardhouse, where he found a dozen poorly shod soldiers whose filthy firearms were hanging on the walls. After Murav'ev asked the officer to demonstrate the soldier's knowledge of the manual of rifle practice and drill, the "slovenly wretches were made to stand at attention and presented arms." Although there were some inaccuracies as well as "uncleanliness of hands, shoes, and weapons," Murav'ev noted the soldiers'

⁹⁴ Vsevolozhskii, *Puteshestvie*, 201.

⁹⁵ The role of mimicry in colonial discourse has been explored by Homi K. Bhabha, "Of Mimicry and Man: The Ambivalence of Colonial Discourse," in his *The Location of Culture* (London: Routledge, 1994), 85–92; in the Russian context, the phenomenon of colonial mimicry is addressed by Susan Layton, "Colonial Mimicry and Disenchantment in Alexander Druzhinin's 'A Russian Circassian' and Other Stories," *Russian Review* 60, 1 (2001): 55–71.

⁹⁶ "Iz zapisok Nikolaia Nikolaevicha Murav'eva-Karskogo," *Russkii arkhiv*, no. 7 (1894): 370.

⁹⁷ Ibid., 373.

skill at handling their arms and concluded that "one could not expect more from a young army." As he pointed out mistakes to the officer but also offered generous words of praise, the Russian envoy relished the idea that his visit would be reported to the *serasker* and the sultan and would produce a positive impression on them.⁹⁸ On another day, Murav'ev ended by showing the Ottoman officers and soldiers the correct balance step. He had them stand for a long time on one foot while waving the other and was surprised to see that "this preoccupies them as though it were an important affair of state." The Russian envoy found strange this "wondrous disposition of the most intelligent Turks to study personally the details of parade-ground drill as though it were a life preserver in their present dire straits."⁹⁹

Murav'ev's amazement at the sight of Ottoman dignitaries learning to march and present arms was not unlike the amusement felt by European observers at Peter the Great's personal engagement with carpentry and smithery.¹⁰⁰ Yet there was a fundamental difference: Westerners may have found Peter's craftsmanship unbecoming his monarchical status, but the reason why the Russian envoy considered the preoccupations of the Ottomans inopportune was the critical condition of their entire state. Murav'ev doubted that the solution to the Ottomans' troubles lay in learning recent military technologies; instead, he stressed the importance of traditional moral qualities. This belief represents an important shift in the Russian critique of the reforms. In response to the Ottoman request for several hundred Russian artillerymen in Turkish uniform to protect Istanbul from the advancing army of Muhammad Ali's son Ibrahim Pasha, Murav'ev told the Ottoman representative that it was "not a time for guns. Instead, you need to act with the scimitar and the sword; you need soul, courage, and loyalty to your sovereign."¹⁰¹

In stressing the foolishness of Ottoman mimicry, Murav'ev's and other 19th-century Russian accounts of the Ottoman Empire were not unlike French or British travelogues about Eastern Europe that focused on the superficiality of the Russian imitation of Western dress, manners, and speech.¹⁰² In both cases, unanimous references to the skin-deep Westernization of the "Other" concealed divergent political outlooks among the authors. For the liberal critics of Tanzimat policies who published in Russian "thick journals" later in the century, the superficiality of Ottoman Westernization was bad because it attested to a

⁹⁸ Ibid., 373–74.

⁹⁹ Ibid., 385.

¹⁰⁰ A. G. Cross, *Peter the Great through British Eyes: Perceptions and Representations of the Tsar since 1698* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 2000), 43.

¹⁰¹ "Iz zapisok Murav'eva-Karskogo," 384–85.

¹⁰² Wolff, *Inventing Eastern Europe*, 23–24, 87–88.

hostility to enlightenment and an inability to assimilate European principles. For people of conservative outlook like Murav'ev, on the contrary, imitating the external forms of Western civilization was bad because it threatened the traditional values that the old-regime elites sought to oppose to emerging modern social forms and practices.

Thus Murav'ev's writings illustrate a conjuncture between Orientalist discourse and a critical attitude toward Western civilization. When taken to the extreme, the latter results in an essentializing representation of the West, a kind of Orientalism in reverse. Such attitudes are particularly common among the representatives of marginal societies and are sometimes referred to as Occidentalism.¹⁰³ While only implicit in Murav'ev and Russian authors writing about the Ottoman Empire during the 1830s, it was eloquently articulated by Konstantin Leont'ev later in the century. The conjuncture between Orientalism and Occidentalism that the Russian accounts of the Ottoman Empire demonstrate should not, however, be understood as uniquely Russian. One finds it in Western authors as well, from Montesquieu's *Persian Letters* in the 18th century to Flaubert's *Salammbô* in the 19th, to Roland Barthes and Julia Kristeva's writings about China in the 20th.¹⁰⁴ In all these cases, the imaginary Orient provides the setting for the articulation of criticism of Western society.¹⁰⁵ The intertwining of the Orientalist and Occidental discourses ultimately reveals the decentering effect of the "margins" where modern Russian identity has always been located and where the Western self has occasionally ventured through real and imaginary journeys.

Conclusion

In the second half of the 19th century, the number of publications about the Ottoman Empire continued to grow, but one observes a general pattern of Orientalization as early as the beginning of the Tanzimat period in the 1840s. One of its central features was the changing politics of how comparisons between the empires were made. Russian accounts always contrasted them, whether implicitly or explicitly, but they did so in remarkably different ways depending on

¹⁰³ James G. Carrier, "Occidentalism: The World Turned Upside Down," *American Ethnologist* 19, 2 (1992): 195–212.

¹⁰⁴ For all these examples, see Lisa Lowe, *Critical Terrains: French and British Orientalisms* (Ithaca, NY: Cornell University Press, 1991).

¹⁰⁵ Nor is it exclusively a textual phenomenon, for one also observes it in the concrete political behavior of British conservatives who eagerly supported the empire as both a means to dominate the Orient and an alternative to disconcerting social and political changes in the metropole. See David Cannadine, *Ornamentalism: How the British Saw Their Empire* (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 2001); and Bernard Porter, *The Absent-Minded Imperialists: Empire, Society, and Culture in Britain* (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 2004).

the period in which they were written. Ignoring the religious divides, Peresvetov posed the Ottoman sultan as a model for the Russian tsar. Later, appreciation for the Ottomans became limited to certain aspects of their military or political organization, and eventually the Ottoman system was found to be lacking in every respect. In the late 18th century, the Ottoman decline was already used to measure Russia's ascent to greatness. The former was not deemed to be irreversible, the latter was still in some way "miraculous," and both were perceived as quite recent. This changed around 1800, when the sultans made their first attempts to emulate Peter the Great. Western observers, who were quick to draw parallels between Mahmud II and the reforming tsar, displayed a range of attitudes toward Ottoman Westernization that ranged from skepticism to enthusiasm. By contrast, Russian authors in this period were more cautious about such comparisons. Their evaluation of Ottoman Westernization was almost uniformly negative. They increasingly portrayed it as "rootless," "superficial," and ultimately unable to stop the imperial decline, which was now seen as prolonged and irreversible. If earlier the Ottomans' ignorance and superstition had been contrasted to Russia's mastery of European arts and sciences, now the "corrupting" effect of the sultan's Westernizing reforms was criticized from the point of view of "nationality," the value of which Russian observers had just discovered. This discursive shift afforded Russian writers a "positional superiority" in their relation with a rival empire, and ultimately allowed them to redescribe Russo-Ottoman relations as relations between "Europe" and the "Orient."

Orientalizing the Ottoman Empire undoubtedly allowed Russian writers to assert their European identity in the face of the references to Russia's own semi-barbarous character that one found at times in the Western literature. Such references must have hurt the pride of educated Russians, for they were judiciously edited out from translations of Western Orientalist writings. Articulated with the help of borrowed idioms, Russian views of Ottoman Turkey can be taken as an example of the "compensatory Orientalism" that helped many peripheral societies overcome their marginality.¹⁰⁶ The struggle for recognition in Europe, however, was not the only thing that informed the triangular relationship among the "West," Russia, and the "Orient." Russian views of the Ottoman Empire

¹⁰⁶ The phenomenon was first explored in the Balkan context. See Milica Bakic-Hayden, "Nesting Orientalisms: The Case of Former Yugoslavia," *Slavic Review* 54, 4 (1995): 917–93. An even more interesting case is provided by Orientalist representations of the Arab provinces of the Ottoman Empire. See Ussama Makdisi, "Ottoman Orientalism," *American Historical Review* 107, 3 (2002): 768–96; and Christoph Herzog and Raoul Motilka, "Orientalism 'alla Turca': Late 19th–Early 20th-Century Ottoman Voyages into the Muslim 'Outback,'" *Die Welt der Islams* 40, 2 (2000): 139–95. In the Russian context, the same phenomenon is analyzed by Sara Dickinson, who uses the example of the symbolic construction of Crimea in the late 18th century in her "Russia's First 'Orient': Characterizing Crimea in 1787," in *Orientalism and Empire in Russia*, 85–106.

also reveal a conjunction of Orientalism and Occidentalism. The latter should be understood not only in the sense of claiming a "Western pedigree" through the recovery of the lands of classical antiquity from under the Oriental yoke, but also in the more conventional meaning of an essentializing depiction of the West by representatives of marginal or non-Western societies.¹⁰⁷ This conjunction became possible as a result of the Westernization policies of Mahmud II, which coincided with the beginning of a reevaluation of the Petrine legacy in Russia. Elements of Occidentalist attitudes are already observable in Russian critiques of Mahmud II's reforms and would become even more pronounced during the Tanzimat period. One should not, however, jump to the conclusion that this conjunction of Orientalism and Occidentalism, peculiar to Russia and perhaps other marginal societies, was simply a reflection of their failure to become part of the West. Instead, it reveals a characteristic ambivalence of Orientalist discourse as such, for was not Western Orientalism itself a critique of 19th-century modernity?

Finally, Russian representations of the Ottoman Empire reveal not only a critical attitude toward the "West" transpiring through a critical portrayal of the "East"; they also functioned as a mirror for Russia itself. Indeed, there was also a significant ambivalence in the depiction of Ottoman Turkey as an Oriental empire attempting awkwardly to adopt foreign models to forestall its own disintegration. However comforting such a representation of an imperial rival was initially, it struck disturbingly close to home once the Crimean War and the latest round of modernizing reforms had revealed Russia's own lack of internal cohesion. By the time of the revolution of 1905, the notion of Asiatic despotism, military inferiority, misconceived reform, and mass popular ignorance was no longer only an image of a faraway land; instead, it became a deadly nightmare that haunted the Russian old regime until its collapse in 1917.

Marion McCain Building, Rm. 1158
6135 University Avenue
Dalhousie University
Halifax, Nova Scotia B3H 4P9 Canada
vitaky2001@yahoo.com

¹⁰⁷ As Dickinson does in "Russia's First Orient," 86–87.

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